What Happened, Why I Started & Why It Matters

How this started, where things stand, and the words you need to read the rest.

What happened

Two cases involving former Sun Prairie West High School staff shaped how a lot of students feel about safety and trust in our district. These are the facts as reported in public court records and the news:

- Robert Gilkey-Meisegeier, a former coach and dean of students, pleaded guilty in federal court to producing child sexual abuse material. On April 28, 2026, he was sentenced to 18 years in federal prison. A related state case was dismissed after the federal conviction.
- Jennifer Ploeger, a former principal, was charged with three misdemeanor counts of failing to report suspected child abuse. On June 25, 2026, she pleaded no contest to one count, the other two were dismissed, and she was placed in a deferred prosecution program. A no contest plea is not an admission of guilt, and she has not been convicted.

Students mostly learned about both cases through rumors and the news, not from the district. That gap is a big reason this work exists.

Sources: WKOW, Apr 28, 2026 · WTMJ, Jun 1, 2026 · WMTV15, Jun 25, 2026 · Spectrum News, Jun 25, 2026. Status as of October 20, 2026.

Why I started

In January 2026, I wrote to the Sun Prairie School Board after a hard stretch in our district left a lot of students unsure what happened and who to trust. I proposed a six-part Student Safety & Trust Framework: clearer communication after serious incidents, a plain explanation of how reporting works, the same rules in every building, a real student voice, better mental health support, and regular check-ins on how it's going.

That letter turned into meetings with district leaders, a new Student Senate at a district high school, students helping choose a principal and a superintendent, a seat on the weighted grades work group, and a proposal for a district-wide Student Advisory Council. Along the way, the same questions about transparency led to meetings with the Sun Prairie Police Department about its license plate reader cameras.

The goal hasn't changed. Student voice should be a regular, documented part of how SPASD makes decisions, not something that depends on one student or one principal.

Why it's important

Students are the people most affected by what happens in our schools, but we're usually the last to hear about it and the least likely to be asked. When something serious happens and nobody tells us anything, rumors fill the gap. That makes it harder to trust the adults who are supposed to keep us safe, and harder to speak up when something is wrong.

In outreach this year, most students said they feel physically safe at school. The problem is follow-through. As one student put it: "Yes I feel safe at school. Yes I would feel comfortable telling an adult. No adults do not listen."

Decisions about grades, safety, communication, and leadership shape the next four years of our lives. Weighted grades and Act 95 decide who gets guaranteed admission to UW schools. How incidents are communicated decides whether we hear the truth or a rumor. Who leads our schools decides how all of that gets handled. Students should have a say before those decisions are final, not find out after.

It also works when it's done right. Students served on principal and superintendent interview panels, helped restart a Student Senate, shaped the weighted grades plan, and got the district to start sending its newsletters to every student. Those changes happened because students asked, followed up, and kept a record.

The same goes beyond school. The license plate reader cameras affect everyone who drives in Sun Prairie, including students and their families. People deserve to know what's being collected, who can see it, and how long it's kept, in plain language.

Why this record exists

I keep every email, invite, and set of notes so the conversations, answers, and commitments don't get lost, and so anyone can check what was said and when. Student names have been removed, except mine. This is an independent, student-led record, not an official Sun Prairie Area School District document, and it is shared in good faith, not to accuse any person.

At a Glance: Where Things Stand

Where things stand (November 10, 2026)

- WON **newsletters to every student.** Asked for at the Oct 20 meeting; the district confirmed in writing on Oct 21 that newsletters will go to students starting in November.
- ANSWERED IN WRITING **LGBTQIA+ protections unchanged** (Oct 1).
- WON **students in the room for leadership hiring.** Students sat on the SPWHS principal interviews and met the superintendent finalists (April).
- WON **a Student Senate restart** at Sun Prairie West, with students elected in April.
- MOVING **weighted grades.** Students helped write the plan and four of them previewed it with Board members on Nov 2. Next: student rehearsal and Board meeting Nov 9, a follow-up with district and school leaders Nov 17, final vote expected late November.
- BUILDING **a District-Wide Student Council.** Proposed to Superintendent Dr. Reed on Oct 29 ("I love this idea"), discussed with him in person Nov 4, then opened to every middle and high school, grades 6–12. Patrick Marsh signed on Nov 5 with 3–5 Peer Ambassadors, Prairie Phoenix's principal wrote that he is supportive, and Sun Prairie East offered its weekly newsletter and SP30, then said on Nov 10 it can't share the invitation until the council is school-sponsored. Still open: how a district-level group registers and who sponsors it.
- ANSWERED **how Board student reps are chosen.** Two-year terms; recruiting starts in December, applications open mid-January for sophomores.
- ANSWERED IN WRITING **license plate readers.** SPPD's written FAQ (Oct 16) and the Chief's Oct 27 answers: a 14-day Axon retention trial, no livestreaming, monthly audits, and a public data-sharing MOU after signing. These are department statements, not contract terms yet.
- ASKED IN WRITING **plate reader records.** Public records request for the Axon estimate, Policy F-18, data-sharing agreements and audit records, filed Nov 9. The Chief also said he's open to a quarterly transparency report once Axon is approved.
- WAITING **the Mayor.** Meeting requested Oct 2.

How to use this record

Part 1 has every contact and every meeting in order. Parts 2–4 cover school district work, Part 5 the license plate reader project, Part 6 emails with the city, police, state and district, and Parts 7–8 the surveys and the public Student Voice pages. Emails appear as cards with the subject, sender, recipients and date. Anything marked as a department or district statement is what officials said, not a signed policy or contract.

Glossary

- **Act 95** — Wisconsin law that guarantees UW admission to top-ranked students, which is why class rank and how GPA is calculated matter.
- **ALPR** — Automated license plate reader: a camera that photographs passing cars and reads the plate.
- **Axon** — The company Sun Prairie plans to switch to for plate readers, starting May 2027.
- **Capstone** — An advanced, project-based course; part of the weighted grades plan.
- **F-18** — SPPD's written policy on license plate readers.
- **Flock** — Flock Safety, the company behind Sun Prairie's current plate reader cameras.
- **Fusus** — Software that can pull camera feeds into a live view. The Chief said there will be no livestreaming.
- **Hotlist** — A list of plates police are looking for, such as stolen cars. A match is an alert, not proof of a crime.
- **MOU** — Memorandum of understanding: a written agreement between agencies, here about sharing plate data.
- **PSC** — The City of Sun Prairie's Public Safety Committee.
- **SP-ALPR** — Sun Prairie ALPR, Zackary's independent project on the city's plate readers (sunprairiealpr.netlify.app).
- **SPASD** — Sun Prairie Area School District.
- **SPPD** — Sun Prairie Police Department.
- **SPWHS / SPW** — Sun Prairie West High School. **SPE** is Sun Prairie East.
- **T&L Committee** — The Board of Education's Teaching & Learning Committee.
- **Weighted grades** — A GPA scale where harder classes (AP, capstones, some dual credit) can count up to 5.0 instead of 4.0.
- **287(g)** — A federal program that lets local agencies help with immigration enforcement. SPPD says plate data won't be shared with agencies in it.
- **Committee of the Whole** — A Board of Education meeting where all members discuss an item in depth before a formal vote.
- **MTSS** — Multi-tiered system of support: a school's layered approach to academic and emotional help, from all students to those needing the most.
- **Outpost** — Axon's solar-powered plate reader camera, the model in the draft Sun Prairie estimate.
- **Peer Ambassadors** — A Patrick Marsh student group whose members may join the student council pilot.
- **PLC** — Professional Learning Center, 220 Kroncke Dr., where the Board of Education meets.
- **SP30** — Sun Prairie East's daily advisory period, where announcements and slides are shared.
- **Public records request** — A request under Wisconsin law for copies of government records.